

Birds

Birds occupy almost every kind of habitat around the world – from hot deserts to the icy polar regions. Of the 10,200 species, some are larger than people while others are barely bigger than bees. All birds have feathers and most of them can fly.

WHAT IS A BIRD?

Any animal that has feathers is a bird. All birds have wings, even those species that cannot fly. Most birds also have very good eyesight and hearing.



EGGS
Birds reproduce by laying eggs and many build nests.



FEATHERS
These enable flight and also provide warmth.



FLIGHT
While most birds can fly, some only walk.



WARM-BLOODED
Like mammals, birds create their own body heat.



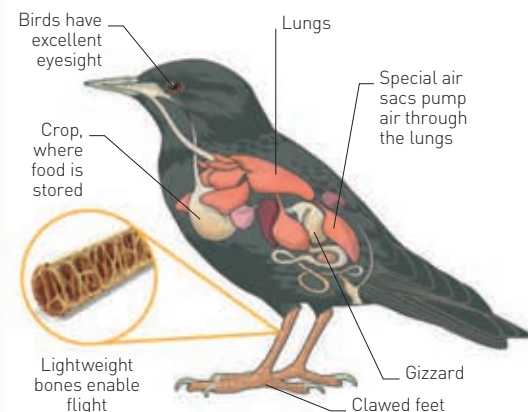
TOOTHLESS BEAK
Having no teeth, birds grind their food in a "gizzard".



CLAWED FEET
Feet and claws come in many different shapes.

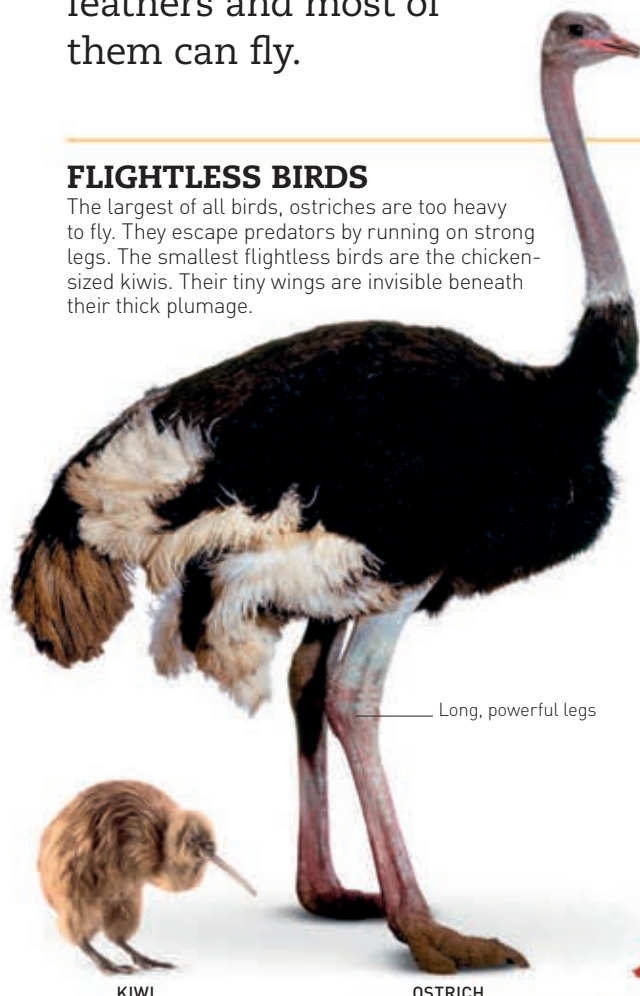
INSIDE A BIRD

Birds have strong yet lightweight skeletons, and large chest muscles to power their wings. Flying burns energy and needs a lot of oxygen. Birds have a series of air sacs in their body to keep up the flow of oxygen through their lungs.



FLIGHTLESS BIRDS

The largest of all birds, ostriches are too heavy to fly. They escape predators by running on strong legs. The smallest flightless birds are the chicken-sized kiwis. Their tiny wings are invisible beneath their thick plumage.



KIWI

OSTRICH

OSTRICHES CAN SPRINT FASTER THAN MOST HORSES CAN GALLOP, REACHING SPEEDS OF UP TO 70 KM/H (43 MPH)

GAME BIRDS

These birds are hunted for food or sport. Most are ground-dwellers, taking flight only to escape from danger. They have strong feet and toes for scraping the ground to find food, and they can run fast.



CUCKOOS AND TURACOS

Turacos live only in Africa, whereas cuckoos are more widespread. Some cuckoo species trick other birds into raising their chicks by laying eggs in their nests.



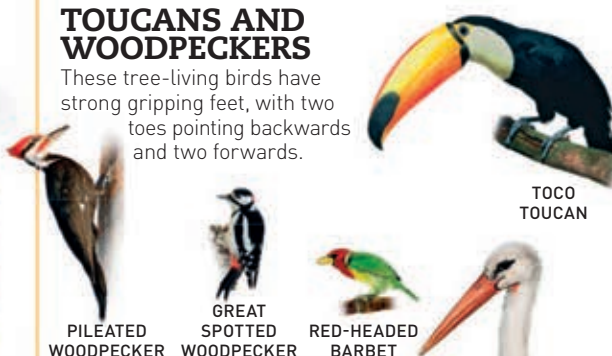
OWLS

These night hunters have forward-facing eyes and see well in poor light. Fringed feathers allow owls to fly without making a sound.



TOUCANS AND WOODPECKERS

These tree-living birds have strong gripping feet, with two toes pointing backwards and two forwards.



BIRDS OF PREY

Eagles, hawks, and falcons are all birds of prey. These swift predators have three things in common: hooked beaks, long talons, and superb eyesight.



PENGUINS

Expert swimmers, penguins have wings that have evolved into flippers. Many species live in the icy waters around Antarctica. A few penguins live in warmer waters further north.

EMPEROR PENGUIN AND CHICK



STORKS, IBISES, AND HERONS

These wading birds stalk prey in shallow waters. Storks and herons make lightning strikes for fish and insects, while ibises probe in mud and under plants.



PELICANS

The long-beaked pelicans, and their relatives the gannets, are fisheaters. Pelicans scoop up their catch in a large throat pouch.

